

Total Recovery

Widow's Bight, 1930s — alternate draft: the record

Ward Kohistani had built his whole method on a single, load-bearing conviction: that nothing worth finding was worth finding partially. A site excavated at ninety percent was a site vandalized by its own excavator — the missing ten was not absence, it was evidence you had thrown away with your own hands, out of impatience or fatigue or the fear of what the last handful of soil might contain. *Total recovery*. He had written the phrase in the front of every field notebook he'd ever owned, underlined twice, and had never once, in eleven years of digging, needed to ask himself what it cost, or what, precisely, it was asking to recover.

He had decided, somewhere in his second year in the field, that the answer was the record and not the object. A find carried out of the ground and into a private cabinet proved nothing on its own — proved less, in fact, the longer it sat unlabelled in some patron's glass case, its provenance thinning with every year nobody asked. A find described, measured, photographed, and left exactly where the ground had kept it proved everything a total recovery needed proving, and proved it to anyone who ever thought to look, not only to the one man rich enough to own the shelf it sat on. He had built his whole career on being the kind of archaeologist a committee could not accuse of looting in the name of scholarship. He did not think of this as a sacrifice. He thought of it as the only version of the work that could survive being looked at closely.

He counted this a virtue. He was thirty-four years old and had never once wondered whether a method built to leave nearly everything exactly where it lay might, eventually, be asked to leave something behind that mattered.

The British Archaeological Society had sent him to Widow's Bight the way a man sends a servant to close up a summer house — a lesser posting, transparently, while the Society's real attention and its real money went to Egypt, to a boy king's tomb and the newspapers that couldn't stop writing about it. Ward read the assignment differently, because he had spent his whole life being handed the lesser posting and needing, each time, to read it as opportunity instead. His mother's family had a name in two countries and full standing in neither — Anglo on paper, Afghan by blood, welcomed by the Crown exactly as far as the Crown found the welcome useful and not one step further. He had learned, young, that the surest way to be let all the way into a room was to be so plainly, undeniably right about something that the room had no further grounds to keep him out of it. He meant to be the most rigorously documented dig in the Society's history, and to make that rigor impossible to file away as a lesser posting's lesser result.

The locals called the laborers who worked the ruins the Observers, and Ward filed the name the way he filed everything, without much interest — folk superstition dressed as an occupational title. They worked the drowned island with a patience he found admirable and a caution he found faintly comic: men who would haul stone all day without complaint and then stop dead, refuse a task outright, over some feature Ward could see nothing wrong with. Oddly colorless to look at against the bright New England light, except for the jewelry a few of them wore, which caught color the way nothing else on that gray coast did.

On his second day the same old man he'd later come to know stood a young apprentice back from the mouth of the lower gallery, and let the boy watch rather than work it. Ward noted the exchange in his book — *apprenticeship structure, informal, merit-based(?)* — and, because documentation was the whole of his method rather than merely a habit of it, went and asked the old man directly what the boy had failed to earn yet.

"Nothing he's failed," the old man said. "Only nothing he's asked for yet, and I'd rather he ask than be handed it."

"You'd let him refuse the work entirely, if that's what he asked."

"I'd let him refuse it forever, if that's the honest answer in him." The old man looked at Ward a while longer than the question warranted. "You write everything down. I've watched you do it three days running."

"It's the discipline."

"It's a kind of asking, too," the old man said, "if you do it carefully enough. Most men who write things down are only proving they were there. A few are actually still listening while they do it. I haven't decided yet which one you are."

Ward wrote the exchange down nearly word for word, and did not, in the moment, hear it as anything other than a colorful local's colorful turn of phrase.

The ruin itself was extraordinary and he loved it with the specific, undivided love of a man who has finally been given the room to be as thorough as he actually is. Chambers below chambers. Corridors that predated any architecture he could confidently date, hung with objects in a state of preservation the salt water should never have allowed. He built his system in the first week and never revised it: full photographic record in situ, full measurement, full Codex entry, before anything at all left the ground — and the vast majority of it never did leave the ground, logged instead exactly where it lay, marked on his own survey map with a precision he was privately proud of.

[ENTRY 001] Carved bone toggle, provenance uncertain, condition fair. Photographed in place. Not recovered. [ENTRY 002] Ballast stone, worked, function unclear. Measured, sketched. Not recovered. [ENTRY 003] Ship's fitting, bronze, heavily encrusted. Recovered — corrosion risk too high to leave exposed.

He carried out perhaps one object in twenty. The rest stayed precisely where four hundred years or four thousand had put them, each one fully accounted for on paper, each one, in his own private accounting, exactly as recovered as anything sitting in a museum drawer — recovered *as a fact*, which struck him as the only kind of recovery that actually mattered, whatever a committee back in London might think when they saw how light his crates came home.

A morning in the third week gave him the cleanest proof of his own method he'd had in years. A corroded ship's bell, heavy enough on its own that carrying it out would have meant abandoning half a day's other work just to manage the climb, sat not four feet from a scrimshawed comb he'd been hunting since his first survey of the gallery. He photographed both from four angles apiece, measured them against a ranging pole, sketched their relative position on the chamber floor with a precision that took the better part of an hour, and carried out neither. He entered the bell's position, the comb's position, and the exact eleven inches separating them, and closed the notebook with the specific, clean satisfaction of a man who has just made an object more permanently known than most objects ever get to be, without laying a hand on either one.

He went back past that chamber a dozen times over the following weeks, always by the same route, always glancing at the bell and the comb exactly where his own notes said they'd be. Nothing about that morning ever suggested to him that a record, however precise, was a different kind of object than the one it described — that a page could survive a man in a way a bell sitting in a flooded chamber could not.

He got better at the leaps. Not through instruction — there was no one to instruct him — but through the plain accumulation of having done it enough times to feel, in his hands and his hips, where a landing would hold and where it wouldn't. In the second week he came down wrong from a ledge misjudged by less than a foot and felt something in his ankle give in a way that made the world go briefly, whitely quiet. He taped it himself, badly, and kept working. By the fifth week the same ledge, and worse ones past it, cost him nothing at all — competence, not a number climbing anywhere he could see it.

It did not make him safe. It only made him cheaper to hurt. A broken toe in the fourth week never fully set right and stayed with him the rest of the season, cataloged the way he cataloged everything, without particular alarm. He understood, dimly, that the ruin was never going to let him climb its worst places for free, whatever he chose to carry out of them afterward.

The opium came from the same crate as the rest of his field kit, meant for exactly this. He used it first the honest way — enough to make the ankle bearable, enough to keep working through a torn muscle that would otherwise have ended his season in its second month. It did precisely what the tin promised and nothing more. It dulled pain. It did not show him anything that was not there. He noticed only much later that the intervals between uses had been shortening for some time, and that this had very little left to do with his toe.

[ENTRY 118] Officer's whistle, brass, corroded. Provenance uncertain. Photographed. Location marked, chamber floor, northeast corner. Not recovered — no clear justification for removal.

He logged it without understanding why the word *officer* had come to his hand before he'd consciously decided what the object was, and left it exactly where it lay, on the theory — his usual theory — that an object this strange deserved a record more than it deserved a crate.

[ENTRY 119] Metal flask, corroded, cap missing. Contents: none. Provenance uncertain. Not recovered.

[ENTRY 121] —

He went back and checked. There was no entry 120. He had not skipped a page, had not torn one out; the numbering simply proceeded from a hundred nineteen to a hundred twenty-one as if his own hand had made the jump without him. He recounted the whole page from the top, arrived at the same gap, and closed the book. A miscount, he told himself, and it worked, mostly, the way it always had.

Further on, scuff marks in old silt, the kind that might have come from a boot dragged sideways in a hurry, or a body pulled somewhere it hadn't chosen to go. He photographed them from three angles, measured their length and depth to the eighth of an inch, and entered them as *evidence of prior disturbance, cause unknown, fully documented*, satisfied, in a way he could not have articulated, that a thing recorded this completely could not really be said to be lost at all — even the part of it he would never understand.

An Observer found him there, once, further down that corridor than any of the local laborers had ever willingly gone, and stood at the edge of his lantern light without a word — grayscale to the collar, a single ring on his hand catching lamp-color no lamp had any business giving it. Ward, for once, did not ask whether the man had something to report. He held up his own notebook instead, an offering rather than a demand.

"I'm not taking anything out of here I don't have to," Ward said. "Whatever this place is, I mean to leave it as intact as I found it. Only better known."

The Observer looked at the notebook a long moment, and then at Ward. "Better known to who," he said. It was not quite a question. "You should ask yourself, sometime before it matters, whether a page is any lighter to carry out of here than a pocketful. I've never been sure it is."

He turned and walked back the way he'd come without waiting for an answer. Ward wrote the exchange down in full, word for word, the way he wrote everything down, and did not, that night or any night after, sit with what the man had actually asked him.

The chapter's second real test came the following week, in a long gallery the sound alone told him was different before his lantern ever confirmed it. The dig's earlier corridors had always carried sound badly; here, for the first time, it sharpened — a dripped stone landing exactly where his ear said it would, his own breathing crisp off the far wall. He logged the acoustic change as a survey note, a genuine curiosity, and used the new clarity exactly as he'd have used any tool that suddenly worked better than expected — placing a dragging sound ahead and below, routing himself along a ledge specifically to keep it beneath him and to his left. It worked perfectly. He crossed the gallery without once losing his footing, and entered the crossing itself as its own detailed record, three paragraphs on the acoustic properties of a stone corridor that, by any geological account, had no business carrying sound that cleanly.

He did not ask himself, writing it up by lantern light afterward, what kind of gallery rewards a man's growing carefulness with better and better information about exactly how much further it wants him to go.

The bloated dead were the first thing in that ruin his method had no honest answer for. He came on them from above, along a ledge he'd have sworn no man his size could hold, and understood before his conscious mind had finished the sentence that whatever lay tangled along the passage floor below him had once, in some cases, been men, and in other cases had simply drowned the way anything drowns, indifferent and unchosen.

There was a piece down among them — worked metal, old beyond anything else he'd catalogued — and for once his usual discipline argued the opposite case than it had with the bell: a piece this significant deserved more than a note and a sketch from thirty feet up; a total record meant getting close enough to measure it properly, not merely closely enough to guess at it. He got as far as one foot off the ledge, testing the drop, before something in him — not caution exactly, something closer to the animal sense a badly-set toe teaches a man whether he wants the lesson or not — pulled the foot back.

Below him, one of the shapes shifted with a groan that had no patience in it. He stood very still and let it settle again, and stayed on the ledge, and entered the piece in his notes from where he stood — *observed at distance, condition and dimensions estimated only, not fully documented, recovery attempt not warranted* — the first entry all season he wrote down knowing it fell short of his own standard, and let it fall short anyway, because the alternative was a standard with no one left alive to keep it. He would never know, because the ruin does not explain itself to the men it lets live a little longer, that the ledge had been the only route that was

ever actually there, and that a fuller record bought at the cost of that last careful step would have been the last entry in any book of his at all.

The opium ran out in the sixth week, cleanly and honestly, the way it had always promised to. No hallucination arrived to replace it. It simply stopped working, because there was none left to work, and the ankle and the toe and the accumulating small violences of the ruin arrived all at once, undulled, and from that point on the exploration Ward had been so proud of narrowed into something closer to a slide. He was no longer choosing corridors so much as following the one his own thoroughness had already committed him to, because turning back now would mean an unfinished record, and an unfinished record was the one entry his method had never once forgiven.

He found the book two nights before the end, wedged with a stack of a dead predecessor's field notes in a niche no team roster listed anyone having reached before him. He photographed it from every angle before he so much as opened the cover — a reflex by then, not a decision — and only afterward read the underlined passage on Aegean mystery cult in a cramped, decades-old hand he did not recognize. Something in his chest went very still and very cold, in a way no artifact in eleven years of careful work had made him feel, and this time he did not merely copy the passage into his own notebook. He took the book itself, the one clean exception to a season built almost entirely around leaving things exactly where they lay, because some part of him understood, without being able to defend the reasoning, that a book belonged with the men who might one day read it rather than with the ground that had only ever been keeping it.

[ENTRY 214] Book. Provenance: unknown. Condition: fair. Prior owner: unknown. Contents: — Recovered, against standing practice. Justification: written record requires a reader; this one had none for decades and would have none for decades more, left where found.

There was no room on the page to finish the description of what the passage actually said. He had, for the first time all season, run out of space in his own Codex, and did not, in that moment, find it strange that the one entry it couldn't hold was also the one entry he'd finally chosen to break his own rule for.

He went on because he had always gone on. He dug because he wanted meaning. He documented because he wanted the meaning to survive him in a form sturdier than memory. He persisted because he wanted, more than either, to be significant to a Society that had sent him here to be forgotten. And he understood, at the very last, in the same clean rigorous hand he'd used for every entry before it, because by then he could no longer stop himself from understanding.

Somewhere in that final stretch he thought, with sudden and total clarity, of the Observer's question — whether a page was any lighter to carry out of here than a pocketful — and understood, far too late for the understanding to do him any good, that a total record was still a total claim, however light his crates came home, and that he had spent eleven years mistaking the weight of what he carried for the size of what he'd taken.

The tunnel beneath the ruin ran on, level and dry, toward an ocean that had no business permitting it, and somewhere along that impossible distance the numbering in his Codex simply stopped meaning anything at all — entries out of order, entries for things he hadn't yet found and would never find, an entry, near what would prove to be the last page he ever filled, reading only *[ENTRY —] recovered in full* in his own hand, in ink, though he had no memory of writing it and nothing left in his pack to explain what it thought it was describing.

He was lost in the depths not long after.

What remained of him was a body with almost nothing on it — no relics, no trinkets, no ten slots' worth of anything a man could point to and call plunder — and beside it a Codex swollen thick with a season's worth of entries more complete, more precisely measured, more honestly hedged than any single artifact he might otherwise have carried out in their place. It would lie undisturbed for the better part of a decade, long enough that his own name passed out of every roster that had once carried it.

It would be another man's own hard year, walking ground he had even less reason than Ward to expect to survive, who came upon the remains at last — a stranger to Ward in every particular that could be named, and would never know Ward's name either, only the enormous, careful patience of a hand that had chosen, again and again, to write a thing down rather than take it, and had, in the one exception it ever made, taken a book that could still be read rather than a bell that could only be admired. He would carry what Ward found the rest of the way down regardless, exactly as it had been left — a record almost entirely intact, a pack almost entirely empty, and nothing about either configuration needing to be embellished, because nothing about this ruin had ever needed to improve on what a man's own choices had already recorded honestly on his behalf.

Total recovery had been the whole of his method, the article of faith he'd built a career on. He had spent it, in the end, on the one thing a season like his was actually able to keep: not the objects, which by his own design mostly never left the ground at all, but the record of them, entire and legible, waiting with a patience that outlasted his own for the one reader who would ever think to ask what any of it had cost him to leave behind.

It never once, in the end, got him.

END OF CHAPTER TWO — ALTERNATE DRAFT